There is something very troubling about this implication that the Jews murdered at Auschwitz were somehow "bourgeois" or perhaps even privileged. No less disturbing are his suggestions that some Germans after 1945 were victims of a few Jewish survivors. Worse still, Snyder diminished German moral responsibility for the Shoah and the role of demonic antisemitism in the Nazi world-view.[15] Moreover, Snyder argues that Stalin was first, not Hitler. This is exactly the argumentation of the prominent German philosopher of history, Ernst Nolte, who notoriously flirted with Holocaust denial in the 1980s.

British historian Brendan Simms is another who argues that antisemitism was not particularly central, let alone the core of Hitler's ideology.[16] In a March 2014 article in *International Affairs*, he claimed that it was "unlikely that [Hitler] was particularly anti-Semitic" prior to 1914.[17] His rather absurd reasoning is that the Hitler family doctor, Eduard Bloch, was Jewish. Simms then presents his claim that even in 1919 Hitler saw the Jewish problem as "a question of mere personal distaste."[18]

Such trivialization and obfuscation of antisemitism might be the reason why Brendan Simms has so many supporters in Germany, including daily newspapers who praised this unbelievably simplistic scholarly article. They included *Die Welt*, the *Franfurter Allgemeine Zeitung*, and *Der Tagesspiegel*.[19] The reviewers in these newspapers were pleased to learn that Hitler became an enemy of the British and Americans before he became an enemy of the Jews.[20] It is evidently congenial to a German audience today to reduce Hitler's antisemitism to a mere offshoot of his anti-capitalist hostility to the Anglo-Saxon powers.

Conclusion

In conclusion, allow me a few general remarks about attitudes to Zionism and Israel in Germany and Europe today. The Gaza War of July 2014 brought to the fore a vicious hard-core antisemitism in which many pro-Hitler statements could be heard at public rallies. They have fused seamlessly with radical left-wing anti-Zionsim, Islamist Jew-hatred, and the inversion of the Holocaust. At the same time in academia we find a growing relativization, minimization, and reductionism when it comes to the Holocaust and the evaluation of Nazi antisemitism. It is not, of course, ignored, but it is nearly always treated as the function or outcome of something else. Moreover, this is happening at a time when the defamation of Israel and Zionism is itself being normalized—a dangerous combination particularly visible in the academic world.

Copyright © 2016. Nebraska. All rights reserved.

Anti-Judaism, Antisemitism, and Delegitimizing Israel, Nebraska, 2016. ProQuest Ebook Central,